

Mindee: An Ogham Chronicles Story

By Cory Huff

"The war is just another way for her to be adored." Colm's voice cut through her like a searing, hot knife. Caile knew that voice. He was her tormentor.

She clenched her jaw and squeezed her eyes shut as the tears flowed. Maybe her fans back home were right. Perhaps she should go home, make more music and perform for the people. Make them forget the doom that was steadily encroaching on their homeland. She would be seen as a hero, rallying the people and keeping their spirits up. She would be given more honors.

When she had walked from her home in the central Hartland woods to Grandmaster Tarkin's house, she had been slightly embarrassed. She wanted to do something selfless. She wanted to do something that wasn't about her. Instead, the road had been lined on both sides with her fans. They tossed flowers. They shouted their love for her. More than a few begged her not to go. Her voice and her dance were artistry. In the horrible, dark times of the Hartland War, they needed someone to help them see a better world.

But all that would only last until the advancing army marched to her home and burned it down. The Amhranaithe were the vaunted blade singers, magical warriors who danced with the blade through the ranks of lesser warriors and unleashed death with sword and magic. If the Amhranaithe didn't succeed, her people, the Tuatha, would die by the swords of Cyric the Warlord's armies. Her old home and people would destroy the place and the people she had called home for so long.

The Tuatha was the name for what humans called elves. That wasn't correct, but they never seemed to understand. The Tuatha had pointed ears and slight, willowy frames, but they were tall and beautiful. Elves was a catch-all term for a wide variety of Sidhe creatures.

Caile closed her eyes against the clenching pressure in her chest and took a deep breath to hold off the rising panic. Her integration into this elite unit was not going well. She leaned her head back and rested it against the rough bark of a redwood tree. She had known that it would be difficult for some of the Amhranaithe to accept her among their ranks. They were the very best warriors in the world. They were the last line of defense the Tuatha had in this war.

Caile's stomach rumbled and woke her from her self-flagellating reverie. Unlike many of the Filid, the singers who kept the oral record of the Tuatha, Caile rarely lost her appetite. Even in stressful, high stakes situations. She laughed at her stomach's gurgling noises. She wiped her eyes, sniffed, and stood up. Nobody would tell by looking at her that she'd been crying. Walking from behind the massive Redwood, she headed to lunch with the Amhranaithe. No more hiding. No more making herself feel better. It wasn't about her. The Tuatha were dying. And they really were her people, despite Colm telling her that she would never belong because she had not grown up among them.

The Amhranaithe warriors had been together for years. They were a tight-knit unit. Some of their members had been sent to bolster the front lines. The remaining warriors missed their friends and worried about them. They didn't talk about it much, but Caile saw the letters that they shared with each other from the front. Some of them had died on those front lines. She had sat in silent vigil in the temple. Every single one was a hero whose feats on the battlefield had turned the tide of a battle or saved the lives of a retreating squadron. Of course Caile didn't fit in. She had never even been in a real battle.

Colm, the soldier who made the crack about her being adored, was sitting at a table with several of his friends. Laughing. She imagined what it would be like to be sitting with them, to partake of their camaraderie, but Caile couldn't help feeling like they were laughing at her. When Colm saw her approaching, he kept smiling. It didn't reach his eyes. She could feel his eyes on her as she made her way to the food line. She forced herself to turn away and pay attention as the cook, a civilian, placed food on her tray. She wasn't sure what it was. It didn't matter. It was just fuel to keep her body going. She had been used to the very best food the Hartland forest could grow, but now she just ate to keep up.

She sat down at a table by herself. She ate mechanically, her mind still focused internally. As she did, she thought about this morning's sparring practice. Just like she did when learning a new dance, she mentally walked through the routines of each of her regular sparring partners. She remembered their steps, and she imagined her own counter-steps. Her legs and feet moved slightly as the muscles fired in response to her inner vision. She thought about yesterday's sparring match. She smiled grimly.

Caile stepped into the sparring ring with Colm. She was feeling good. Loose. She held her practice longsword in her right hand. No sweat would make her lose her grip today, despite the warm weather. Colm was bigger than her, though not by much. Still, he had that constant smirking grin on his face, like he was confident he would beat her easily.

The call to start coming. Colm charged her, just as she had watched him do many times before in practice. Unlike most the blade singers, Colm's song was more of a shout, and his dance tended to overwhelm his opponent quickly. He probably thought it would be easy to best her. Colm made it a point to humiliate those who were new. Caile thought he was overconfident.

She studied the forms intensely. The Amhranaithe dances are basic footwork used to train new soldiers how to move, thrust, parry, and swing all while maintaining balance enough to dodge, parry, counterattack, and keep the distance required to drop a battle spell on an opponent. These soldiers had practiced the forms for longer than she had. But one reason she had even been given an opportunity with the Amhranaithe was because of her dance ability. Caile had trained as a dancer from a young age and was the most famous dancer in the Hartland. The other reason she had been given a chance was the Ogham magic. Caile had mastered the subtle aspects of the Ogham many years ago and used it to charm her audiences. She only had to learn to adapt it to battle.

All of this flashed through her mind in the fraction of a second it took for Colm's charge to bring him within swinging distance. He was quick with his sword. Caile made as if to block the swing, pushing her weapon to the left. Colm seized on her bluff, putting even more force into the blow, likely planning to blast through her block and knock her down. But she put no weight behind her parry. Instead, she lunged forward to the right, keeping just ahead of his swing and lowering her own weapon as she did so. She got just the right angle, driving her blunted practice weapon into his ankle, causing him to stumble. She pulled the stroke through and quickly reversed, hitting him in the back of the thigh. A sharp weapon would have hamstrung him, leaving him crippled. She danced to the right as he tried to turn to meet her and she drove her blunted practice sword down hard across his back, kicking him to push herself away as he fell down.

It was a devastating series of blows, executed perfectly. Caile was quick, agile, and her footwork was impeccable. Any other Amhranaithe who executed at that level in her training would have received a chorus of accolades.

But Caile was not any other beginner.

Colm stood up slowly. The crowd was silent. Caile lowered her weapon, thinking the match was over. "Thank you," she said, trying to contain her excitement as she gave a slight bow, the accepted formal response from a young soldier to a veteran. She looked around at the crowd. She saw grim faces, jaws set. One younger soldier, her only friend, named Ceren, mouthed a wow at her but quickly looked away.

Colm's face was red. He was embarrassed. He was the first full Amhranaithe that Caile had bested in a sparring match, and it had not been close. "Again," he said, raising his weapon. Caile hesitated for only a moment before raising her weapon to signify she was ready. He charged in again, more measured this time, but still aiming to overwhelm her. He chopped across once, twice, three times. Caile danced away. A triple step to the side in time with his weapon swings. He growled and came on harder. "Half human bitch, stand still."

Caile suddenly reversed course. Her balance perfect, she thrust her sword point directly into Colm's chest. He got his sword up in time to deflect the worst of it, but her sword dragged across his chest from his heart up and over his collarbone. She retracted the thrust and deflected the counterattack wide. He growled and spat out, "Half human bitch."

Caile had enough. Not only was he slow on his feet, but he was also slow and repetitive with insults as well. She feinted at his heart again. He moved to deflect, and she changed direction, aiming for his diaphragm. "You're dead," she said as she lowered her sword point and muscled in, making him grunt in pain. She didn't see his right fist until it smashed into her face. Suddenly she was on the ground. He was on top of her. His left hand gripped her throat, pinning her down and choking her. His right hand smashed into her face again. The leather gloved fist hit her two, three, four times in rapid succession before she could begin to respond.

She got her left arm up to protect her head, but the choking was a problem. She grabbed the thumb of his left hand just as she had learned in grappling class, and bent it back, as hard and fast as she could. He snarled in pain as the thumb snapped. It was the opening she needed. She pulled her knees up and kicked him off of her. She gulped in air, coughing, scrambling to her feet as quickly as she could while trying to clear her vision and get her bearings.

The training master for the day, an honorary position picked by the sergeant, grabbed Colm before he could charge back in, yelling at him, "The match is over Colm. You lost. Go to the infirmary and get your thumb splinted." The training master shoved Colm out of the ring. He walked off with several other soldiers. Nobody asked Caile if she was well. Nobody congratulated her on her victory. The crowd melted away as Caile stood there, shaking.

The training master watched them all go. He then turned to her. He looked her up and down, then spoke, "breaking bones is forbidden in sparring. One demerit for breaking Colm's thumb." He waited for her to acknowledge him. She heard him as if he were underwater. Other voices yelled at her. Where were they coming from? The training master called her name sharply, "Caile, are you alright?"

Caile sat in front of her lunch, trembling, mostly unaware of where she lay. Instead, she flinched as she remembered being hit over and over again. She heard someone yelling out, "Seinn, are you alright?"

Who is Seinn? What was happening to her?

Caile snapped out of her reverie. Her food was mostly gone. She didn't remember eating any of it. The tables around her were empty. Everyone had left and gone back to training. One of the cooks watched her. "Are you well?" she asked Caile.

Caile nodded, shook herself, and stood up to go. Her stomach hurt. Her digestion was suffering from this mediocre food. She had not been herself the last few days. She would not seek help though. She needed to be as hardened as the others.

Caile ran to get back to training. When she arrived, breathless, everyone was already mid-drill. The sergeant, the one who assigned each day's training master, barked at her, "You're late. Run." She immediately began running laps around the large grass-covered training field that had been cut in the woods. She ran in hot Summer heat until she was dripping in sweat and her breath was heaving. Nobody told her to stop, so she just kept running. She puked from exertion. She ran more. Sometime after she collapsed from exhaustion and couldn't stand anymore, the sergeant noticed and he was there, standing over her, yelling, "What's wrong Caile? Too good to be on time and now you're too good to run? This isn't the green room before you go on stage. This is soldier training! Get up! Get up and get running again Caile! Or just go home. Go home and I'm sure your fans will greet you with flowers and cheering. None of them will ever know how weak you were here."

While he was yelling at her, Caile retreated within her mind. She mentally ran away from the sergeant's abuse. She also ran away from some other dark figure screaming at her. Was it a man? Had he hurt her sometime in the past? She sought the strength to lift her body off the ground. Her brain knew that she had reached her physical limit. Somewhere, deep in the recesses of her mind, there was a presence. Someone was watching. She should be scared, but somehow the presence was familiar. This presence was no other. It was her. But not her. It had been there for a long time. When she was small and everyone had failed to protect her, this presence had been there. Now that Caile was at the brink again, the presence made herself known. She? Yes. Her name was Mindee. Mindee insisted that she be in charge. Caile relinquished control.

The sergeant was still yelling. "Quit now Caile! You're weak! You're going to get yourself and these soldiers killed. You'll never be a real soldier!" The sergeant knew that she had been running for over an hour and that not a single one of the Amhranaithe would take the abuse he was dishing out. They had all stopped drills and were watching.

They all gasped when she slowly stood up. There was an audible, "Whoa" from Ceren, who had joined up at the same time as her and was not doing nearly as well. She wobbled a little bit. Then she took off, jogging at first, then running. Her gait was flawed from exhaustion, but she was running.

"Half human freak," she heard Colm mutter as she passed.

"I heard humans can run all day and that's why we're having such a hard time fighting them," muttered his astonished sparring partner. "I guess it's interesting to have one of them on our side, just to see what they're capable of doing."

Mindee had been in this situation before. She knew more about what this body was capable of than Caile did. The sergeant was right. Caile was weak. She had allowed herself to become soft as her fame grew. Mindee pushed the body and ran. It was tired. It wasn't functioning as well, but it still ran. Caile wanted to do this, but she wasn't capable of continuing. So Mindee would do it. Like she did whenever things became dangerous. Mindee attuned to the rhythm of nature and the Ogham stones, drawing on the magic to enhance her body's natural strength and senses. This made it easier for her to breathe and it also sharpened her hearing. She heard soldiers quietly talking about her mixed heritage. She tuned them out and concentrated on the sergeant, trying to figure out if she would be forced to run to death.

"I don't think she's going to make it, sir," said the sergeant to Grandmaster Tarkin. The Amhranaithe Grandmaster had stopped by to check in on the progress of training. The battle at the front lines was not going well. Another dozen of the mystical blade singers had died yesterday. They had killed more than a hundred humans in a heroic stand that would be written about by the Filid singers. If the Filid and the rest of the Tuatha survived this insane genocidal war of Cyric's. Mindee supposed that Caile would want to join those front lines as soon as possible.

"Why not?" Asked Tarkin. He was old, but he still carried his powerfully ensorcelled longsword. He still stood straight despite his completely grey hair tied up in a bun and the wrinkles around his eyes. He even stood straight despite the aches and pains in his joints. He couldn't dance much anymore, but his command of the Ogham magic more than made up for whatever physical deficiencies age had wrought upon him.

The sergeant responded, "Sir, she's not one of us. She doesn't get along with the others."

Tarkin considered this for a while. "Have you tried to help her fit in? She is well enough liked among the Tuatha."

The sergeant nodded, "I'll do what I can sir."

Mindee knew that Caile would be gratified that they wanted her to fit in. Mindee just wanted to survive. It didn't sound like she was going to die today, and that was enough for her to keep running.

Caile woke and sat up. It took her a moment to realize where she was. In her bunk. How had she gotten here? She tried to slow her breathing. What was the last thing she remembered? Running. Running and collapsing and puking. The sergeant screaming at her. She would not give up. She would not allow them to force her to quit. How had she gotten from there to her bunk?

Mindee. Mindee had come to the rescue. She had taken control. Mindee didn't care how her body hurt. Mindee didn't care how upset she was. Mindee had a job to do. Mindee had forced her body to stand and move. Mindee had noticed her joints were hurting and had accessed the Ogham magic to make her own body lighter and easier to move. Caile felt nausea as she realized how powerful Mindee was. She also felt a rush of heat in her chest as she realized that her body was stronger than she had thought. Mindee had shown her that. It had been a long time since Mindee had come out. Nobody else knew about Mindee. Caile hadn't thought of Mindee in many years. Caile couldn't remember what had happened after the running. She racked her brain to figure out how she had gotten to the bunk. She bit her lip to keep from crying at the thought of not being in control of her own body.

"Caile?" A quiet voice came from next to her bunk, followed by some quiet laughter. Her bunk was in the corner, near the door, on the bottom. The loudest spot, with only one way off. She looked up. "What?"

Colm loomed over her. He shoved a rag in her face. It covered her mouth and nose. She flinched away, but suddenly his buddies were there, too, grabbing her legs and arms. There were too many of them. She screamed, but the rag muffled everything. Her heart pounded. Her vision swam. This shouldn't be happening here. She knew she was an outsider, but the vows of the Amhranaithe were supposed to be inviolable. They weren't supposed to do things like this.

"Shut up! Stop struggling, and this will go quickly," he hissed in her face. She couldn't tell exactly where she was. It was as if she were seeing two different places at the same time, through her eyes and through someone else's. Not Mindee. Who was this other presence in her mind?

She was in two different places. She was in her bunk struggling with Colm. She was in a bed in her childhood home. There was suddenly another man holding her jaw with an enormous iron grip. It covered the bottom half of her face, smothering her. He was doing something with his other hand. He was touching her in a place that hurt. She panicked and kicked and struggled, but she couldn't do anything to stop him. Some part of her brain noticed that it wasn't that his hand was enormous. He wasn't a giant. She was a child. She was Seinn. She wept because Seinn hurt so much.

In one place she laid there, unable to stop the terrible pain being inflicted on her small body. In another place and time, she was being carried somewhere. It felt like she was floating. Now in both times, she was floating. Her soul was floating. Her body was floating. Was she floating to heaven? Was she going to die?

She saw her mother floating. Her mother was floating on a bed. No, she was lying on a bed. Seinn floated over to the bed and tried to touch her mother. Her arm wasn't working. She tried to wake her mother. She shouted, and in the other place someone hissed at her again, "I said be quiet. This will be over soon."

She cried. The tears were wet on her cheeks. She was suddenly in a bath. She had decided that since her mother couldn't get up, she would take a bath. So here she was, in the water. Floating again. Seinne's friend Dubhaine, the one that everyone said was just her imaginary friend, said, "Remember, you have to use the Ogham to get yourself free and swim up. You can't breathe under there."

The two places suddenly snapped into one. Seinn and Dubhaine quieted, uncertain. Caile wasn't in a bath. She was underwater. She barely avoided taking a breath in surprise. What had happened? Which way was up? It was the middle of the night. It was dark. She was surrounded by freezing cold water. She couldn't see her hand in front of her face. She needed to get out now. She couldn't think of what to do.

Mindee demanded to be in charge and Caile fled. Mindee made a single gesture, and a small globe of light appeared in the water in front of her. She let some air out of her lungs and watched the direction the bubbles floated. She swam that direction, making herself lighter in the process. She nearly shot her entire body out of the surface of the water, then settled back down, bobbing up to her waist before taking a deep breath. Mindee gulped air. In the background of her mind, Caile whimpered a thank you. Seinn screamed in terror and receded into the black depths of her mind, going silent. Dubhaine spoke to Mindee, "they really scared Seinn and Caile. We need to do something about this. Let's confront Colm and put an end to this."

Mindee swam to the shore of the pond. She shrugged off the other Amhranaithe who tried to help her out of the water. Wordlessly, she stalked up to Colm, who had a big grin on his face. He spread his arms wide, "Welcome Caile. You're one of us now. You made it."

Mindee stiffened her fingers and thrust them at Colm's throat. He saw it coming and flinched back enough to soften the blow. She had meant to kill him by crushing his trachea. Instead, she just hurt him badly. The others grabbed her, bearing her to the ground when she refused to stop struggling and trying to get to Colm, who coughed and choked on the ground, holding his throat.

She heard their voices calling on Caile to stop. "Caile, stop. It was just a joke! Stop! We're not trying to hurt you." Dubhaine spoke to Mindee, "I said confront him Mindee, this is crazy! You nearly killed him! No! Don't grab your boot knife that will make it worse!"

Mindee ignored Dubhaine. Colm was a threat. She would end that threat for good. She reached with her right hand for her boot knife. Her left hand moved in arcane gestures. The air before her trembled with energy.

One of the Amhranaithe yelled at her, "Sorry Caile, but we have to do this."

Sudden pain. Blackness.

Mindee sat in Grandmaster Tarkin's house in the same large, overstuffed red velvet wingback chair Caile sat in nearly a year ago.

"I want to join the Amhranaithe," she had said then.

"It will be difficult. Are you sure you really want to do this?" was Tarkin's response.

Now he was throwing her out. The sergeant and Colm were telling Tarkin that she had attacked Colm. "It was hazing," said the sergeant, glaring at Colm who looked at the floor. "But her response was completely unwarranted. She tried to pull a knife."

"We have to tell them what happened," Caile spoke directly to Mindee, in a silent conversation only the two of them could hear.

"It won't matter."

"We could explain what happened. We could tell them about you."

"How will you explain me?" Mindee's logic was cold. "You don't even understand why I'm here."

"You're here because I needed you to save me."

"And how will you convince them I won't try to kill Colm? Because I will. Next time I'm alone with him, he dies."

Tarkin was speaking. Mindee ignored Caile's response and listened to him. "Caile," he said, thinking that the woman sitting before him was simply the woman the world knew as a famous Filid, "Tradition and unity are a core part of what makes the Amhranaithe great. Your actions have ruined any chance of you being a part of that. I told you this would be difficult. You are out."

As Tarkin spoke, Mindee nodded. They would no longer be in danger from Colm. She receded into the background. With a shudder that the others in the room took for a sob, Caile fronted in the body again.

A seed of an idea took root in Caile. If she couldn't protect her people this way, perhaps she could protect them in another way. There was another powerful group that would teach her how to fight using the Ogham stones. This group is secretive. They work behind the scenes. That might even be a better fit for what she already knew how to do. Caile had heard that they had brought the magical Ogham stones to humanity on behalf of the Archfey.

"Who are the Cumhnantach?" said Caile.

Tarkin blinked. He wasn't used to being interrupted. The sergeant and Colm jerked to attention, their bodies full of tension at her interrupting Tarkin. Tarkin's face became a neutral mask. "Why do you want to know that?"

"Well, if you're going to throw me out of the Amhranaithe, I might as well make myself useful in some other way," Caile responded. "I'm not just going to slink back to being a singer. I want to serve."

The two soldiers looked confused. Tarkin stared at her for a long time, his face blank. "Leave us," he gestured to the door. The sergeant and Colm left.

When they were gone Tarkin spoke, "You have no idea what you're suggesting. I strongly recommend that you drop this line of inquiry and go home Caile."

"I'm not a child. You can't just send me home Grandmaster. I'm out of the Amhranaithe. I don't have to listen to you." Caile was furious. No matter where she lived, how she conducted herself, there was always some person telling her how to live her life.

"You say you are not a child. What do you know about them?" Tarkin asked, calm and seemingly intrigued.

"I've heard that they want to stop Cyric. Stop the war."

Tarkin smiled a sad smile. "Yes, that's part of it. They want to see the war stopped. They want to stop Cyric, but not for the same reasons the Amhranaithe do. Not because of the suffering of human and Tuatha. They have their own motives, Caile. Those motives are not friendly to our cause. Those motives are personal. Here's the only thing you need to know. Not long ago, Cyric was their leader. Their desire to control everything about the Ogham stones allowed Cyric to manipulate humanity into starting this war."

"So they have great reason to stop him." She responded.

Tarkin smiled that sad smile again. "I've warned you Caile. These are not good people. You were not a good fit for the Amhranaithe, but that doesn't mean you don't have a good heart. I believe you do. Don't go down this road."

A year later, Caile crept through the woods in the dark. She wasn't the most accomplished at woodcraft, but she had excellent body control and she could be very quiet. She summoned all of her focus and even a little bit of the Ogham power to keep herself as quiet as possible.

For the last year, she had been seeking the Cumhnantach. Tarkin had absolutely refused to give her any information. She had reached out to well-connected friends. She greased palms with her money. She spent most of her small fortune traveling back and forth across the Hartland, into the Dragonspine mountains, East into the Saeserin swamp, and behind the battle lines South into Ghealdar.

She had watched thousands of people die, human and Tuatha. Cyric's war had crossed over into genocide. The human army was massive. It seethed and raged and devoured everything in its path. She had watched in horror the one victory the Tuatha had in Ghealdar. Tens of thousands of humans had died. She had sobbed and retched at the death.

All of her tracking and rumor hunting trying to find the Cumhnantach had brought her back here, to her adopted homeland. The Hartland forest was home to the Cumhnantach, or at least one home. They met here, at a circle of standing stones that she had never seen for all her ramblings through the forest. She watched a group of 10 figures in long, black, deep-hooded robes gathering. They had shaken hands and spoken so quietly that she couldn't hear them. She wanted to get closer, but there was too much space between the stones and the trees for her to move without being seen.

After a few minutes of conversation, another black-robed figure stepped out of the woods. The rest stopped and turned toward that figure. They all went quiet. Together, they wove a complex series of Ogham invocations that Caile surmised were meant to protect from eavesdropping. She kept perfectly still.

When leaves rustled behind her, she startled and threw a glance over her shoulder. Two black-robed figures stood just a few feet away, looking right at her. She smiled at her own failure.

"I'm here to join you and help put an end to the war," she said.

A quick gesture from one of them and she scrambled to her feet to further explain herself. The other made a series of gestures and she realized they were invoking the Ogham.

"I'm no threat to you," said Caile.

But the grass suddenly grew, wrapping around her feet. She made her own arcane gestures, spelling out the word for escape in the Ogham alphabet and her feet were freed. She stepped backward out of her grasping grass and into the clearing. "I'm no threat to you, and I have power. Let me join you."

One of the figures made an annoyed sound and flung a hand out at her. She screamed as her body was stabbed with a dozen invisible daggers. She looked around at her body. There were no wounds. She willed herself to stagger to the side, to run, but the pain was so immense that her mind was foggy. The pain came again after she took just a few steps. She screamed and fell to her knees. A soft voice said, "Stop struggling, and it won't hurt so much."

She twisted and fell to her side to see who was speaking. One of the black-robed figures stood just a few feet away. Another one stood a little further off, holding a hand out toward her. His fingers moved, and another line of agony ran down her back, like she had been slashed from right shoulder to left flank. She screamed in pain again.

“Who are you?” The soft-voiced figure.

She panted and breathed out, “I am Caile. The singer. I am here to join the Cumhnantach.” She had rolled onto her stomach because her back hurt so much. She spoke into the ground. “I want to help stop the war.”

“You are one of Tarkin’s soldiers. Did you think we wouldn’t know?” The pain became stabbing knives in her kidneys. She screamed and screamed.

When she finally got her breath again she panted into the dirt, “I’m not! I swear I’m not! I left the Amhranaithe a year ago. They kicked me out.” Someone grabbed her shoulder and quickly heaved her over onto her back. She flinched as she expected her wounds to hurt touching the ground, but the wounds weren’t real. Just the pain.

The two figures were standing over her. Several others were in the background. The one who was torturing her spoke in a deep voice, “She’s a liar. This is not the first infiltrator Tarkin has sent. Do we kill her?”

The quiet one spoke, “Let’s see what she knows.”

Her torturer grabbed her by the jaw, locking eyes. “You will reveal everything to me.” There was a familiarity with the move that made Caile’s mind spin out of control. Seinn wordlessly screamed. Dubhaine called, “Mindee, come back, it’s happening again.”

Caile’s memories flashed before her eyes. He was doing this somehow. He was pushing into her mind, pulling out her memories. Her travels through Ghealdar and the horrors of tens of thousands of deaths he brushed past without a thought. Her being kicked out of the Amhranaithe. He lingered on that, observing it and playing back again. Her being thrown in the pond as a hazing exercise, which she now recognized was probably meant to be friendly. Mindee fronting to protect her and avenge her near-drowning. The Cumhnantach wizard hesitated. She could feel his mind pull back and wonder. Mindee was her protector. She was usually quiet, in the background, watching. Present but passive. But now there was danger.

Mindee surged, and Caile let her. There was a threat. Mindee would end it. This man was grabbing her as that other man had done. Mindee generally saw herself as unsentimental, but this man woke within her an aching rage that instantly turned to an inferno. Not only had he seen her, but he had treated her in a way that she vowed would never happen again.

Mindee somehow drew upon the Ogham and threw the man out of her mind. He shuddered as Mindee's mental assault stunned him. She pulled her boot knife and before anyone could react, stabbed the neck of her torturer. Blood sprayed everywhere, especially over Mindee. She didn't flinch but instead pulled out the knife while grabbing him by the back of the neck and plunging the knife in again harder, twisting it. Both stabs happened in an instant.

The force of the Ogham, like invisible hands, restrained her arms, pulling them back over her head in a painful stretch. She listened to the gurgling sounds as the black-robed member of the Cumhnantach bled out. The rest of them yelled about what to do. She had neutralized the threat. She watched the black-robed figure with the soft voice pull back his hood to reveal blonde hair and a fey face. He looked at her with a curled lip of disgust...and admiration?

One of the other black-robed figures knelt next to the one she'd stabbed and said, "He's dead.

"Obviously," said the blonde man in front of her. "You broke your restraints and threw him out of your mind. What else can you do?"

Mindee slipped over the ten foot high stone wall of the city of Atania in the dark. There were no guards to worry about. With the Ogham to lighten her weight, she had scaled it with ease. She quietly wandered through the broken cobblestone streets of the city where she had spent her childhood.

Mindee never thought of the dozens of people she had murdered. The Cumhnantach had welcomed her, even though they hadn't made her a member. They had accepted her help. They used her training, skills, and ability to pass for human to devastating effect. They used their magic to identify the human army's leaders, the ones that Cyric called his Chosen.

As Mindee eliminated them with deadly precision, the human army weakened. Without strong leadership, their ability to surround and harass the Tuatha had dissolved into confusion. It ended at Dragonshome peak when Cyric was defeated by Darian Bloodstone. The Winter Queen ascended the Sidhe throne, and the Gaeas had been implemented, causing humanity to forget the Ogham stones and all of the magic that had come with them. The Cumhnantach had been the only humans exempted from the Gaeas, with the understanding that they would watch over humanity and prevent them from regaining the magic.

Mindee had a crucial role in ensuring that happened.

She had her orders from the Cumhnantach. Caile wanted them followed so Mindee would carry them out. Find the humans who were violating the Gaeas and eliminate them. By culling the magic from the herd of humanity, she would prevent the recurrence of the Hartland War.

By preventing the magic from coming back, Mindee would prevent the Winter Queen from justifying genocide as self-defense against the genocidal tendencies of humanity that Cyric had awoken in them. She would keep humanity alive and the Tuatha alive.

Even if they never knew she did.

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Want more stories about Mindee and the rest of the Ogham Chronicles? Join the newsletter at CoryHuff.com. The next novel in the series, *The Unkindness of Ravens*, is due out in early 2019.

Cory Huff is a writer, story teller, and actor living in Portland, Oregon.